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What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Home sales finished 2025** with strong momentum, rising 5.1% in December, but the year as a whole ranked among the worst sales slumps in decades. **A1**
- ◆ **The parent of Saks Fifth Avenue and Neiman Marcus** filed for bankruptcy protection barely a year after the two storied retailers were brought together. **A1**
- ◆ **Meta Platforms laid off** roughly 1,500 people from its Reality Labs division, the unit that houses its virtual- and augmented-reality efforts. **B1**
- ◆ **Tech stocks, including** Nvidia and other chip companies, retreated, helping to pull down the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow industrials by 0.5%, 1% and 0.1%, respectively. **B1**
- ◆ **Trump-appointed Fed** governor Stephen Miran criticized global central bankers who defended Jerome Powell amid the Justice Department's criminal probe. **A2**
- ◆ **Banks reported that** American consumers continued to spend and borrow at a healthy clip at the end of 2025, despite concerns about job security and inflation. **B1**
- ◆ **OpenAI entered into** a multibillion-dollar agreement to buy computing capacity from Cerebras Systems, which is backed by Sam Altman. **B1**
- ◆ **Verizon said it** resolved an hourslong, widespread outage that prevented customers from making calls and sending messages. **B2**
- ◆ **Elon Musk said Tesla** would stop selling a suite of advanced driver-assistance features for a one-time payment and would switch to a monthly subscription service. **B3**

Worldwide

- ◆ **Trump said he was** told that Iran suspended plans to proceed with executions of anti-government protesters, hours after Tehran signaled it was preparing swift trials and executions in defiance of a warning from the president. **A1, A6**
- ◆ **A three-judge panel** rejected the Trump administration's effort to block California's congressional map that adds five new Democratic-leaning districts for the 2026 midterms. **A3**
- ◆ **The State Department** will indefinitely pause immigrant visa processing for 75 countries as part of the administration's effort to block low-income foreigners from immigrating to the U.S. **A3**
- ◆ **FBI agents searched** the home of a Washington Post reporter as part of an investigation into alleged mishandling of classified information by a government contractor. **A3**
- ◆ **The Senate voted** to kill a war-powers resolution aimed at limiting Trump's authority in Venezuela after two pivotal Republicans said they had received assurances from the administration. **A4**
- ◆ **A deadline passed** for the Smithsonian Institution to produce documents demanded by the White House, but it was unclear what the president intended to do with them. **A4**
- ◆ **Top officials from** Denmark and Greenland conceded they hadn't persuaded Trump to abandon his ambitions to annex Greenland after a visit to the White House. **A7**
- ◆ **Japanese Prime Minister** Sanae Takaichi was set to call a snap election, intending to cement her grip on power. **A8**

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A woman flashes a victory sign under a banner in Tehran showing hands firmly holding Iranian flags as a sign of patriotism.

Iran Suspends Plans to Execute Detained Protesters, Trump Says

President doesn't indicate if military campaign against Tehran will occur

President Trump said he was told Iran suspended plans to move forward with executions of antigovernment protesters, hours after Tehran signaled it was preparing swift trials and executions in defiance of a warning from

By Feliz Solomon, David S. Cloud and Benoit Faucon

testers, hours after Tehran signaled it was preparing swift trials and executions in defiance of a warning from

Trump and the threat of U.S. military action.

"That's just gotten to me, some information, that the killing has stopped, that the executions have stopped," Trump said Wednesday afternoon.

The family of Erfan Soltani, a 26-year-old man who was arrested on Jan. 8, had been told his death sentence would be carried out on Wednesday, said Awyer Shekhi of Hengaw Organization for Human Rights, a Norway-based nonprofit. A relative of Soltani's later said her family had heard the sentence wouldn't be carried out that day after all.

"Until the family speaks to

Erfan and sees him in person, we cannot be sure whether it was carried out today or not," the relative said in an interview.

Hengaw said the execution order had been postponed.

Trump's statement about Iran suspending planned executions came as he told the country's protesters in recent days that "help is on the way." Iran has warned it would retaliate if the U.S. strikes, and the Pentagon has begun evacuations from the region.

Iran's judiciary chief, Gholamhossein Mohseni-Ejei, said earlier on Wednesday that the courts should act quickly against protesters, who have

swept across the country with demonstrations in recent days.

"If we want to do a job, we should do it now. If we want to do something, we have to do it quickly," he said in a video released by Iranian state television.

The group Human Rights Activists in Iran said on Wednesday the death toll had surpassed 2,400, as the regime has moved to crush the demonstrations. It said more than 140 members of the government security forces had been killed

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◆ **Caribbean buildup limits** U.S. options in Iran..... **A6**

Home Sales Log December Rise Amid '25 Slump

Despite a surprise lift last month, the full year downturn is one of worst in decades

By NICOLE FRIEDMAN

Home sales finished 2025 with surprisingly strong momentum, rising 5.1% in December for the biggest gain in nearly two years. But even with last month's boost, the year as a whole still ranks as one of the worst sales slumps in decades.

The increase in sales, which was more than double what economists surveyed by The Wall Street Journal had expected, reflected easing mortgage rates and slower growth in home prices.

On a monthly basis, the existing-home sales gain was the biggest since February 2024 and the fourth-straight monthly increase, the National Association of Realtors said Wednesday. The four consecutive months of rising sales is the longest streak since 2020.

Despite the increase in activity in December, 2025 marked the third straight year of dismal sales, falling to a level that by one measure represented the worst slump for the housing market in more than four decades. Existing-home sales of 4.06 million last year held at their lowest level since 1995, NAR said.

The higher sales in December

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◆ **FHFA head takes aim at** home-builder buybacks.. **A2**

Saks Files Chapter 11 As Luxury Bet Sours

By SUZANNE KAPNER AND BECKY YERAK

The parent of Saks Fifth Avenue and Neiman Marcus filed for bankruptcy protection Wednesday, barely a year after an ambitious bet on luxury department stores brought the two storied retailers together in what was supposed to be a powerhouse deal.

The swift unraveling of Saks Global shows the perils of doubling down on department stores, whose golden days are long past. The plan behind the \$2.7 billion merger was to create a luxury juggernaut, while cost savings from the deal were expected to help Saks dig out of a deepening hole of delayed payments to suppliers.

But with a roughly \$100 million debt payment that was due in December and sales declining, the company ran out of time. It is now the highest-profile department-store chain to file for chapter 11 since the Covid-19 pandemic.

Geoffroy van Raemdonck, the former chief executive of Neiman Marcus, has been picked to lead Saks through bankruptcy as its CEO, effective immediately. In all, Saks has secured about \$1.75 billion in financing for the process, the company said early Wednesday.

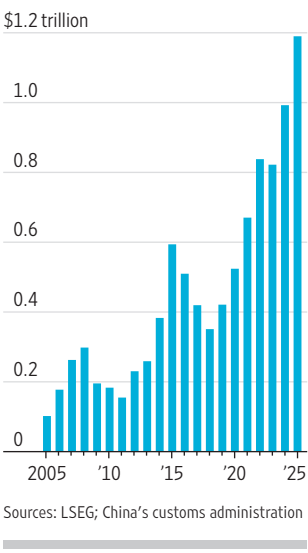
In its filing, Saks Global said it owed financial debts of about \$3.4 billion. Its creditors are many of the most notable names in the fashion industry.

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China's Trade Surplus Soars

Despite U.S. tariffs, China's 2025 trade surplus reached a record \$1.19 trillion. **A8**

China's goods trade surplus



Power Grid Has An AI Problem

Largest grid operator in the U.S. strains under demands of data centers

By KATHERINE BLUNT AND JENNIFER HILLER

America's AI boom is pushing the nation's largest power-grid operator to the brink of a supply crisis.

Sixty-seven million people in a 13-state region stretching from New Jersey to Kentucky get their power from a market operated by non-profit PJM. So, too, do the many AI data centers springing up in Northern Virginia's "Data Center Alley," which have a bottomless appetite for electricity.

Rates are going up for consumers. Older power plants are going out of service faster than new ones can be built. And the grid's capacity is in danger of maxing out during periods of high demand, which could force PJM to call for rolling blackouts during heat waves or deep freezes to avoid damaging grid infrastructure.

Mark Christie, former chairman of the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission, said that a few years

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Get Travelers To Dress Up? It Won't Fly

Government links bad behavior to sweatpants

By DEAN SEAL

Could dressing nicer get air travelers to behave better? The U.S. government thinks so. Passengers might be a tougher sell.

The Transportation Department kicked off the 2025 holiday travel season with an admittedly unenforceable civility campaign aimed at bringing back "courtesy and class to air travel." Since 2019, in-flight outbursts have climbed fivefold, with a particular surge around the pandemic, according to the Federal Aviation Administration.

If more fliers opt for jeans

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Maduro Ouster Clouds China's Regional Goals

By LINGLING WEI

The Trump administration's ouster of the Venezuelan strongman Nicolás Maduro is forcing Beijing into a high-stakes recalculation of its ambitions in a region that looks like the U.S.'s backyard again, people close to internal discussions in the Chinese leadership said.

For years, China made inroads into Latin America, coaxing countries to abandon support for Taiwan with loans to build roads, ports and rail lines, making significant purchases of commodities like soybeans and oil, and mining metals such as copper. Maduro was its most important ally, an anti-U.S. leader with oil resources, earning Venezuela the rare distinction of an "all-weather" partnership—China's highest diplomatic honor and a status held by no other country in Latin America.

Now, Beijing is no longer

seeking to make new advances into the region in the near term, the people said. Instead, the discourse in China's policymaking circles has shifted toward a potential trade-off: If the Western Hemisphere belongs to the U.S., then the Taiwan Strait belongs to the Chinese.

This calculation doesn't mean China views the U.S. action in Venezuela as a green light for an immediate move to take back Taiwan, a democratically ruled island that Beijing views as a breakaway province. Rather, U.S. action against Maduro by force bolsters China as it gives priority to its "core interests," chiefly, bringing Taiwan under its control.

China's leaders had been watching its influence in Latin America wane since President Trump returned to the White House a year ago.

Mexico recently imposed 50% tariffs on Chinese electric

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